



» RANJI DIARY

The curious case of the runaway ball

Faulty ground design turned an ordinary day of First-Class cricket into an **amusing spectacle.**



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The Goa Cricket Association (GCA) Ground in Porvorim is one of the most oddly placed cricket stadiums this Diary has encountered.

A standard cricket pavilion enclosing the GCA offices occupies one side, while two others are flanked by Goan government buildings — the SCERT office and the Directorate of Accounts.

And the fourth? A busy state highway, busier than usual because of flyover construction nearby.

What separated this road from the GCA ground was a four-foot wall, with a three-foot metallic net mounted on it.

But the wall had an obvious shortcoming — a large gate, which

happened to be one of the first things the Diary noticed upon arriving at the ground on the eve of the Ranji Trophy match between Goa and Kerala.

To paint a picture — the gate was angled parallel to the central square, with grills wide enough for a cricket ball to pass through.

As the game started, the Diary was consumed by a singular intrusive thought — would someone manage to hit a ball over the wall or maybe even get it through the gate?

It took three days of waiting, but the Diary's manifestation did churn into reality.

Off the very first ball he faced in senior cricket, Kerala wicketkeeper-batter Manav Krishna pulled a short one from Goan pacer Arjun Tendulkar (**left**). The ball skipped past the boundary and hopped right in the direction of the gate, much to the Diary's 'elation'.

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